

GIRAFFES



WITH ITS MASSIVE neck and long legs, the giraffe is the world's

tallest animal. Despite its ungainly appearance, it is very graceful.

Giraffes live in the savannahs of Africa – grasslands with a few trees and bushes. Their distribution closely follows that of the acacia trees on which they feed. They avoid open grassland because of their feeding habits, but also because their size makes them conspicuous in the open. There is only one species of giraffe, but eight subspecies, which differ mainly in the colour and pattern of their coats.

Herds

Giraffes usually live in small groups of up to about 12 females and their calves. Adult males live apart and visit the herd only for mating. Occasionally, giraffes gather together in large groups of up to 70 animals that stay together for a few days, or sometimes just a few hours.

Coat markings

Giraffe markings range from regular geometric patterns to irregular fuzzy-edged patterns. Old males darken with age and may become almost jet black.



Reticulated giraffe



Rothschild's giraffe



Masai giraffe

Standing still and staring towards a potential threat acts as a warning sign of danger.



Giraffes have exceptionally good eyesight.

Okapi

The giraffe's only living relative, the okapi, is a much smaller animal, with shorter limbs and neck. While the giraffe lives in herds for mutual protection and is active by day, the forest-dwelling okapi is a solitary animal, active by night. It lives in the tropical rainforests of Zaire. The okapi's vision is poor, but its hearing and sense of smell are acute and more useful in the forests where visibility is limited.

Males have horns



Large ears

Deep chestnut-coloured coat

Creamy-white, or light grey, markings help camouflage the okapi.

Striped legs

Thick rubbery lips and saliva protect a giraffe's tongue and mouth from thorns.

An adult male giraffe can stand 5.3 m (17.5 ft) high.

Short mane

The giraffe's long neck has the same number of vertebrae as other mammals, but they are larger.

Reticulated giraffes have regular russet-coloured markings.

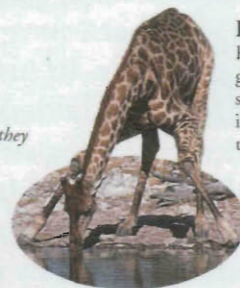
Hoof

Reticulated giraffe



Browsing

The giraffe's great height is a specialized adaptation for browsing the upper branches of trees. Leaves and small twigs form the greater part of the giraffe's diet. It also eats shoots, flowers, fruit, seed pods, even bark, but never grass. Many acacias and other trees have vicious thorns to discourage browsing, but the giraffe's tongue is well equipped to get past such strong defences.



Drinking

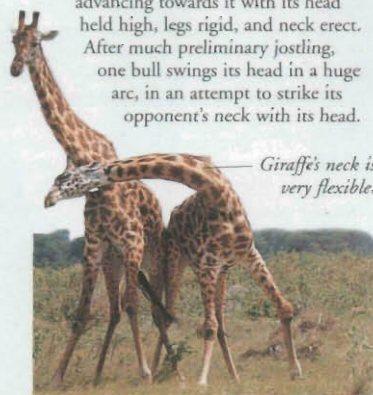
For an animal as tall as the giraffe, drinking presents special problems. To lower its head the giraffe has either to bend its knees forward or to extend its forelegs out to either side. This awkward posture greatly reduces the animal's field of vision, leaving it vulnerable to attack.

Features of a giraffe

Massive shoulder blades carry the huge muscles that support the giraffe's head and long neck. Its hind legs are shorter than its forelegs, but the angle of the back makes them appear shorter than they really are. By breaking up its outline against its surroundings, a giraffe's coat markings help to camouflage it.

Necking

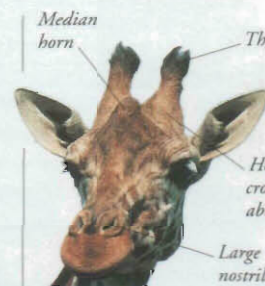
Necking is a form of ritualized sparring that determines dominance within a group. It begins with one bull challenging another by advancing towards it with its head held high, legs rigid, and neck erect. After much preliminary jostling, one bull swings its head in a huge arc, in an attempt to strike its opponent's neck with its head.



Giraffe's neck is very flexible.

Horns

Giraffes of both sexes have a pair of short stubby horns, about 30 cm (12 in) in length in an adult male. Some giraffes, such as the reticulated giraffe, have a third (median) horn in the middle. Rothschild's giraffe also has a small pair of horns behind the ears, for which reason it is often known as the "five-horned giraffe".



Median horn

The horns are covered with hairy skin.

Horns grow on the crown of the head above the eyes.

Large nostrils

RETICULATED GIRAFFE

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Giraffa camelopardalis reticulata*

ORDER Artiodactyla

FAMILY Giraffidae

DISTRIBUTION Africa south of the Sahara

HABITAT Savannahs

DIET Leaves, shoots, small twigs, flowers, and fruit

SIZE Height: males 5.3 m (17.5 ft); females 4.5 m (15 ft)

LIFESPAN 25 years